country's shores from the villages, it got damaged, thanks to the unreliable transport network, i.e., chiefly bullock carts. Worse, during times of drought and famine, the bullock carts got further delayed; on such occasions, ships were kept waiting at ports for goods that never arrived. With a rail line, things would change drastically. Cotton, and indeed every raw material, would get transported with remarkable speed to the sea ports. From there, the cotton could be sent by ship to Britain and its hungry textile mills. Back then, cotton, a crucial commodity for the textile industry in the United Kingdom (UK), was mainly purchased from America. Though India, too, used to export cotton, the quantities were minuscule. However, Britain did not want to be dependent exclusively on America for cotton, and from the 1840s, showed deep interest in cotton cultivation in India.

J.A. Turner, resident of the Manchester Commercial Association, in fact wrote a letter in 1847 that clearly explained the aim of establishing the railways.

> I believe that if Indian cotton is sent home clean, there will be an increased demand for it; and that it is very unlikely that the spinners will discontinue using it, even if American cotton recedes from its present value; though of course they would, in such cases, only use it at its relative value compared with the American. [26]

Another need for a faster mode of transport was military might. It was a fact that besides giving the growing native population better mobility, railways would enable faster deployment of troops.

Besides cotton trade, military use of the railway line would prove of immense benefit, and a letter [27] to that effect written by Thomas Williamson, Revenue Commissioner of Bombay, to the chairman of the Great Indian Peninsular Railway (GIPR) company, Lord Wharncliffe, in May 1846, is self-explanatory. He recommended an alignment through the Malshej Ghats .

> I need not remind your Lordship that Bombay is the great focus of our military strength in western India. Its admirable harbour, at the most centrical [*sic* ] point on the west coast of the Peninsula, has since the time of our first connection with India, pointed it out as the key of our possessions in this quarter. There are our Dockyards, our Arsenals, our Manufactories of Ordnance and other stores; and it is the only point on the whole coast where troops can, at all times of the year, be embarked and disembarked without difficulty or delay.
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> In Europe, the importance of a railway as a military work is limited to the speed and comfort with which large bodies of troops may be conveyed to their destination; but in India its value is enhanced by the mode in which it would spare the health and save the lives of European troops.